allow divisive forces to weaken us. We need to overcome these forces as one strong unified nation.'

For Ratan, the call to rebuild what has been destroyed also included the restoration of the Taj to its old glory. And this was not just important because the iconic hotel was older than Tata Steel or that it was perhaps the face of the Tata Group. In a way, the Taj had come to symbolize the nation after the attacks. It was necessary to convey to anyone who was watching that no one would be able to kill the spirit of the nation and Mumbai.

Ratan was not alone in harbouring such strong sentiments. Batliwala reveals that amongst the countless letters that were received in the aftermath of the attacks declaring solidarity with the group and Ratan, there was one from a farmer in rural Maharashtra. In it, he expressed his anguish at what had happened and his worry about whether the heavy expenditure involved in the restoration work would dissuade the Tata Group from undertaking it. He stated that the Taj represented India and it had to be rebuilt at any cost and added that as the expense involved would be huge, he would also like to contribute to the effort to show the world that India's will cannot be broken. Along with the letter, he sent a cheque of Rs 5,000 as his contribution.

As Ratan declared to Fareed Zakaria: 'We're all committed that we will build back this hotel to what it is. However long it takes, whatever it takes, this hotel will stand. I can only say that it somehow epitomizes the will of my great-grandfather, because it stood up to all the abuse it has.'

He kept his promise and, within a month of the attack, on 21 December 2008, the Taj once again opened its doors to welcome guests. Ratan's defiance was evident during the function. He said: 'We can be hurt but we cannot be knocked down.' Although Kang calls Ratan a 'corporate saint', he says that doesn't mean Ratan will not fight back. 'He is at the strongest when he is cornered,' remarks Kang.

Standing on the porch of the iconic building, Ratan declared, 'She has stood for more than a hundred years and will stand for a hundred more.' It was a message of defiance. He said that the hotel staff had worked overtime to ensure that it was back in operation in 'a record time'. And he made it a symbol of victory by dedicating the hotel to the victims of the attack, and calling the reopening the 'start of a new era'. He also said that he 'hates to look back' and the reopening was the Taj's 'show of strength' to the whole world.